CHAPTER 45

STILL JIMMY

19–21 May 2016

ENGLAND vs SRI LANKA, 1st Test, *Headingley, Leeds*

England 298; Sri Lanka 91 and 119

England won by an innings and 88 runs

Sri Lanka 1st innings: **J Anderson 11.4–6–16–5**; 2nd innings: **J Anderson 13.3–5–29–5**

Although every summer now rolls into the next, a routine of cricket, then family, then cricket, then family, forming my life's structure, I am entering a phase of consistency with the ball that I have not yet reached. As I do so, the voices outside grow louder on the subject of retirement. It starts or ends every conversation. The better I play, the more it is talked about. It is like fighting against the elements, walking against that current back in Burnley, up that hill, on to that bench where I can be whoever I want to be.

Despite the outside chaos, I am feeling more and more in control. I know that I can block outside thoughts. That is all they are, thoughts. I am in control of how everything moves. My mindset during games now moves less frequently to the wilder emotions and the sulks. When I find myself there, I speak to myself quickly, reset and begin again. I am also taking myself outside of cricket more regularly, to keep my body at the absolute height of its performance. I am focusing much more on the technique of running itself. Without a ball in hand I do hip drills daily, take to hurdle sprint work and spend lots of time watching sprinters take off out of the markers, their economy of movement and efficiency through the air, as I try to get myself somewhere close to what they do when I run up. I am running